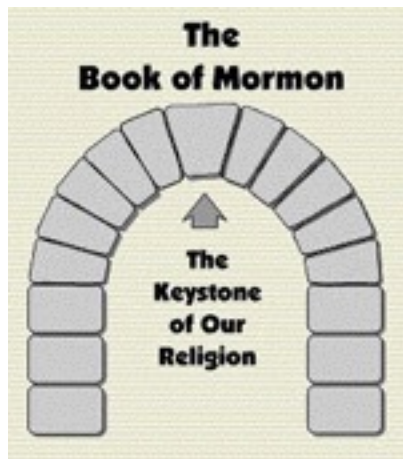


BKM 1 Enrichment



(See Charles Beardall: [Book of Mormon Lesson 1](#))

E1. Daniel Walker Howe on the Book of Mormon:

“True or not, the Book of Mormon is a powerful epic written on a grand scale with a host of characters, a narrative of human struggle and conflict, of divine intervention, heroic good and atrocious evil, of prophecy, morality and law. Its narrative structure is complex. The idiom is that of the King James Version, which most Americans assumed to be appropriate for divine revelation. Although it contains elements that suggest the environment of New York in the 1820 (for example, episodes paralleling the Masonic / Antimasonic controversy), the dominant themes are biblical, prophetic, and patriarchal, not democratic or optimistic. It tells a tragic story, of a people who, though possessed of the true faith, fail in the end. Yet it does not convey a message of despair; God’s will cannot ultimately be frustrated. The Book of Mormon should rank among the great achievements of American literature, but it has never been accorded the status it deserves, since Mormons deny Joseph Smith’s authorship, and non-Mormons, dismissing the book as a fraud, have been more likely to ridicule than to read it.” (Daniel Walker Howe, *What Hath God Wrought: The Transformation of America, 1815-1848* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 314.)

[Note: [Daniel Walker Howe](#) “is Rhodes Professor of American History Emeritus at Oxford University in England and Professor of History Emeritus at the University of California, Los Angeles. He won the 2008 Pulitzer Prize for History for *What Hath God Wrought* (2007), [1] his most famous book.” Wikipedia.]

E2. New York City Book Club in 1938: “Brother William E. Berrett gives an account of an interesting gathering in New York City in 1938. It was the New York City Book Club. Their speaker was the Honorable Henry A. Wallace, then Secretary of Agriculture. His subject was “Good Books of the Nineteenth Century.” In the course of his remarks he said, “The greatest book published in the nineteenth century in the field of religion was the Book of Mormon. Although this book was read by less than one percent of Americans, it affected that one percent so powerfully as to change the history of the nation.”

Brother Berrett states further, “It is a book that has aroused a storm of protest. It has done what the Prophet Joseph said it would do. It has divided men into two camps—those who are for it and those who are against it. There have [possibly] been more books written against it than against any book ever published in America. ... On the shelves of the Church Library in the Church Office Building there are more than 1,500 [anti-Mormon] books, each of which, in a portion of its pages, makes an attack on the Book of Mormon. Fifteen hundred volumes by fifteen hundred separate authors. Of those fifteen hundred probably only two ever reached a second edition. ...” (William E. Berrett, “What Is the Book of Mormon?” in *Know Your Religion Series* 1953–54, 21 Oct. 1953, pp. 1–2.)

...
[Elder Cullimore related two fascinating stories of the Book of Mormon’s role in converting multiple people.

“The first is about James Monroe Hastings and his wife, Eddie. Mr. Hastings was a Baptist minister in New Mexico during the depression days of the early 1930s. After one of his revival meetings, someone gave him a Book of Mormon which he took home and placed on the shelf...

...
The other experience was related to me by a good friend. He gave a Book of Mormon to one of his associates in business... When he saw him again, the friend said, “Possibly you’d like to know what happened to your Book of Mormon? I haven’t read it, but many of my family have, and there are now nineteen of my family members in your church as a result of reading it.

“I took the book home and put it on the shelf. One night as my mother was babysitting for us, she saw the book and began to read it. When we came home, she asked us about it. She said, ‘This book is true.’ This started a chain of events that brought about these many baptisms.” (James A. Cullimore (Assistant to the Twelve), “[The Book of Mormon](#),” *Ensign*, May 1976.)

E3. The "Reverend" Jones:

In the fall of 1983, I graduated from the Navy Chaplain's Basic Course in Newport, Rhode Island. At that time I was not prepared for certain anti-Mormon encounters I was going to experience. My orders directed me to report to the First Marine Division at Camp Pendleton where I was to be assigned to a Marine infantry battalion.

The battalion was located at a remote site called Camp Horno. At a Division staff meeting, the executive officer commented on my assignment, "Ah, Horno, the oven. That's what it means in Spanish you know." Then he smiled as though I would discover "Horno" soon enough.

One week later I was introducing myself to the battalion staff officers and as I made my rounds to get acquainted, each officer asked, "Have you met Reverend Jones yet?"

When I said I had not, they responded, "Don't worry, you will."

A Marine battalion consists of about 750 men divided into five companies. Corporal Jones was assigned to Lima Company and I inquired among the enlisted Marines to learn more about the notable "Reverend" Jones. They told me he was on leave (as was most of the battalion) recovering from the six-month deployment they had just completed the week before. He was a Marine corporal who had been a former drug addict. He had been converted to Christ and relieved of his powerful addiction to drugs with this dramatic shift in his life. Since that time he had become a persuasive lay preacher for Christ. Preaching and testifying of Christ was all he did in his spare time. He was like a kind of mosquito to those who weren't interested in his message (which was most of the battalion), they just brushed him aside. But he had some followers who banded with him to try and reach the others.

I finally met him at the recreation offices two weeks later. He was ironing a uniform for the inspection the next morning. He seemed pleased to see me and asked a few questions about the scriptures. Then he showed me a lesson plan from a Bible class and asked me what I thought about it. I made a comment he seemed to like. Finally, he asked which faith group I belonged to and I told him "Mormon". He did not react negatively to that and seemed to know nothing about our faith. We said little more as he finished ironing his shirt. He said he had to go to a revival at the Eagle's Nest, a prominent place for Evangelical worship and fellowship. Hence our beginning was rather friendly.

He attended all my worship services in the field for about six months until the day he saw a virulent anti-Mormon movie at the Eagle's Nest. From then on he refused to attend my services and sought to persuade others that Mormonism was of the devil.

About a year passed and our battalion boarded three troop carrying assault ships to spend six months in the Pacific. I rode the largest troop

transport. It was a giant ship nearly 900 feet long and much like a small aircraft carrier. It carried helicopters and trucks and could transport (with the crew) about 2600 men.

As our tour neared its end, I was re-assigned to a smaller ship for our two-week return trip to Hawaii. This happened to be the ship where "Reverend" Jones was assigned.

During the trip I asked him to attend my services, but he would not. Furthermore he persuaded the ship's protestant lay leader and nearly all the other Protestants on board ship that Mormon's weren't Christian. Thus, they wouldn't attend either.

Fortunately, the protestant lay leader let me show him the Book of Mormon to see it for himself. He saw the introduction and many of the verses, which testified powerfully of Christ. After seeing the truth, he decided to support me and convinced a few of the other Protestants to attend my divine services.

Corporal Jones led his own little worship service. I let him use my office for that purpose and even attended his first session, but I prepared to speak with him when he returned the key after the second session.

When he called at my stateroom, I invited him in and said, "I believe the movie you saw doesn't square with the truth. I know Christ is my Savior and have been taught that from my youth. May I ask why you think our faith is of the devil?"

He responded with an objection.

"I don't know the answer," I said, "but I do know that Jesus Christ is my Lord and I know that from the Book of Mormon which was written to bring us to Christ. May I show it to you and let you judge for yourself?"

When he consented, I showed him the translated preface in which I had highlighted: "to the convincing of the Jew and Gentile that JESUS is the CHRIST, the ETERNAL GOD."

It seemed important that he trust what I would tell him about the Book of Mormon, so in terms he knew, I outlined my experience as a Mormon by saying, "I've been a member of many congregations; served as a missionary for two years; graduated from our formal religious training programs; taught innumerable gospel classes and pastored a congregation. I know what is commonly taught in our church. This Book of Mormon (which I cradled in my hands) is our standard for doctrine and I'd like you to see for yourself what it says about Jesus Christ."

With that we sat side by side while I turned to Second Nephi in chapter twenty-five. I let him hear the sincerity in my voice while I read verse 26 with him:

And we talk of Christ, we rejoice in Christ, we preach of Christ, we prophesy of Christ, and we write according to our prophecies, that our children may know to what source they may

look for a remission of their sins (2 Nephi 25:26).

I showed him other passages, but finally took him to the last page and told him about Moroni who was the last prophet to write in the Book of Mormon. I noted that Moroni watched the destruction of their civilized nation because they rejected Christ and his teachings. Then I showed him Moroni's final plea.

Yea, come unto Christ, and be perfected in him, and deny yourselves of all ungodliness; that by his grace ye may be perfect in Christ

And again, if ye by the grace of God are perfect in Christ, and deny not his power, then are ye sanctified in Christ by the grace of God, through the shedding of the blood of Christ, which is in the covenant of the Father unto the remission of your sins, that ye become holy, without spot. (Moroni 10:32-33.)

I said, "The Book of Mormon is our scripture. It begins with Christ. It continues with Christ. It ends with Christ. It refers to Christ "more frequently per verse" than even the New Testament. Its record of Christ's visit to America establishes his concern for all people and even its final words call men to him.

I paused and watched while he pondered, staring intently at the scriptures before him.

After a long silence he said, "I guess I'll have to read the Book of Mormon. Do you have another copy?"

That was my last day aboard his ship. As I left the following morning though, he and one of his friends met me on the dock to express their friendship and wish me well. Then they departed for Waikiki. I never saw either of them again, but the marvelous testimonies of Christ found in the Book of Mormon enabled us to part as friends, and they enabled Reverend Jones to see the Book of Mormon in an entirely new light. I also know that the Book of Mormon brought me closer to Christ than I had ever thought possible. The Lord had answered my prayers with divine precision and opened my eyes to see the importance of Christ as I had never seen him before.

Reflecting on the experience again and again, I began to sense the great convincing power of the Book of Mormon. (See Stephen M. Bird, *Prayers That Bring Miracles*, (Murray, Utah: Aspen Books, 1997), 77-83 in the hardcover edition.)

E4. Richard Lloyd Anderson: "The Three Witnesses left the church because they disagreed with Joseph's policies, but they never once threw doubt upon their testimonies. (Even Peter and Paul, who had both seen visions, sharply disagreed on policy at times.) Had they not really seen the plates, when they were out of the church, the Three Witnesses would have disavowed their

experience, and they would not have tried to keep ties with the church. All three witnesses left the church for a time, but two came back before their deaths to make peace with God, and they all continued to bear witness to the Book of Mormon and their vision of the plates to the end." (Richard Lloyd Anderson, "[Book of Mormon Witnesses](#)," Maxwell Institute, Provo, Utah)

E5. Complexity, Ignorance, and Probabilities

All of these complexities (whether internal, external, or "hidden") count as evidence for the authenticity of the Book of Mormon because of the assumption of Joseph Smith's inexperience or ignorance. Arguments based on these complexities assume that Joseph Smith did not know enough to have been able to produce the complexities. The weight of some of these evidences also depends on the accuracy of the witnesses' description of the process of translation (see Richard L. Bushman's discussion of that process in chapter 2)—specifically the time and other resources that were available to Joseph Smith in translating the book or the manner in which he worked. Other complexities would be extremely difficult to account for, no matter how much time Joseph might have had or what resources he could have consulted, given the nature of secular knowledge on the subject at that time. That difficulty increases as the number of instances of the argument increase. That is, we are dealing with probabilities. Each example shows that it is improbable that Joseph Smith could have created the book. As examples multiply, the possibility that Joseph Smith merely got lucky repeatedly or that he had access to nonsupernatural sources of knowledge on a wide variety of topics of which we are unaware becomes increasingly unlikely, to the point of being incredible.²¹ (Melvin J. Thorne, "[Complexity, Consistency, Ignorance, and Probabilities](#)," in *Book of Mormon Authorship: Revisited*, Chapter 7.)

E6. "Find a Book of Mormon. Hold it. Riffle through some of the pages. Examine the type and the text. The book is real. It exists. This has become a great dilemma for some of our detractors and enemies. Since the book is here, it must have come from somewhere. For 170 years, a multitude of people has been trying to explain where exactly that was. Hugh Nibley spoke of this predicament. He said:

There are three possible explanations for the origin of the Book of Mormon. One is that it is a product of spontaneous generation. Another is that it came into existence in the way Joseph Smith said it did, by special messengers and gifts from God. The third is the hypothesis that Joseph Smith or some other party or parties simply made it all up. No experiments have ever been carried out for testing any of these theories. The first has not even been considered, the

second has been dismissed with a contemptuous wave of the hand, and the third has been accepted without question or hesitation.

And yet the third theory is quite as extravagant as the other two, demanding unlimited gullibility and the suspension of all critical judgment in any who would accept it. It is based on the simple proposition that since people have written books, somebody, namely Smith or a contemporary, wrote this one. But to make this thesis stick is to show not only that people have written big books, but that somebody has been able to produce a big book like this one. But no other such book exists. Where will you find another work remotely approaching the Book of Mormon in scope and daring? It appears suddenly out of nothing—not an accumulation of twenty-five years like the Koran, but a single staggering performance, bursting on a shocked and scandalized world like an explosion, the full-blown history of an ancient people, following them through all the trials, triumphs, and vicissitudes of a thousand years without a break, telling how a civilization originated, rose to momentary greatness, and passed away, giving due attention to every phase of civilized history in a densely compact and rapidly moving story that interweaves dozens of plots with an inexhaustible fertility of invention and an uncanny consistency that is never caught in a slip or contradiction. We respectfully solicit the name of any student or professor in the world who could come within ten thousand miles of such a performance. As a sheer tour-de-force there is nothing like it. The theory that Joseph Smith wrote the Book of Mormon simply will not stand examination (*Collected Works of Hugh Nibley*, Vol.7, Ch.6, pp.137, 138. Cited in Ted L. Gibbons' blog: "[Book of Mormon Sunday School Lesson 1: The Keystone of Our Religion](#)," LDSLiving.com, Dec. 28, 2015).

E7. Additional Teaching Ideas

2. Sharing the Book of Mormon

"Consult with the bishopric and the ward mission leader about how members can obtain copies of the Book of Mormon to share with nonmember friends and acquaintances.

"In class, suggest that a class goal this year should be to share the Book of Mormon with nonmember friends and acquaintances. Explain to class members how they may obtain copies of the Book of Mormon, and encourage each class member to give a copy to at least one friend or acquaintance during the year.

"Several times during the year, as the Spirit directs, ask class members if any of them have yet shared a copy of the Book of Mormon. Invite class members who have done this to briefly describe the experience. Continue to encourage class members to share the Book of Mormon with others." (*Lesson Manual*)

Recommended Reading:

1. President Marion G. Romney, "[The Book of Mormon](#)," *Ensign*, May 1980, 67).
2. James A. Cullimore (Assistant to the Twelve), "[The Book of Mormon](#)," *Ensign*, May 1976.
3. Nancy Jensen, [Book of Mormon Lesson #1 "The Keystone of Our Religion"](#), LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus, December 23, 2011.
4. Monte Shelley, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#)), Monte Shelley GD Lesson Notes. Select 2016 BofM. Select 1) Introduction. Select Monte Shelley GD Lesson Notes.
5. "[The Keystone of Our Religion](#)," BYU Studies Quarterly.
6. [2016 Gospel Doctrine—Recommended Resources on the Book of Mormon \(updated\)](#), Ben S., Times and Seasons, December 19, 2015.
7. Neal Rappleye, "[A New Way to Study and Share the Book of Mormon](#)," Meridian, December 28, 2015. This article introduces a new Book of Mormon Resources website: Book of Mormon Central.
8. [Book of Mormon Central.org](#).
9. Ted L. Gibbons, "[Book of Mormon Sunday School Lesson 1: The Keystone of Our Religion](#)," LDSLiving.com, Dec. 28, 2015.
10. [Book of Mormon Study Resources](#) by LDS Living, Dec. 16, 2011.
11. "[Complexity, Consistency, Ignorance, and Probabilities](#)," Melvin J. Thorne, *Book of Mormon Authorship: Revisited*, Chapter 7.

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